Design welcome emails for thumbs, not designers

The best-supported design for a marketing or lifecycle welcome email is a **single-column, fluid layout capped at about 600px, with one message and one primary live-text button in the first phone screen, 16px body text, and a system-font fallback that looks right without the web font**. That design has to survive Gmail stripping custom fonts, classic Outlook dropping rounded corners and animation, dark-mode colour inversion, and Gmail clipping any message whose HTML exceeds about 102KB. Readers scan rather than read: Nielsen Norman Group's eye-tracking found people spend about **51 seconds** on a newsletter and fully read only **19%** of them, so the action and its benefit belong at the top. For GoFindBuild, two brand-specific problems come before everything else. **White text on brand orange #F16C0E has a contrast ratio of 3.05:1, which fails WCAG AA for normal-size text** such as button labels; navy text on orange (5.09:1) passes. And **the navy #16243D logo drops to about 1.21:1 against dark-mode backgrounds**, so it effectively disappears for dark-mode readers. On sequencing, the vendor default is about three emails in the first week with email 1 sent immediately. GoFindBuild's 7-email (job seeker) and 6-email (employer) flows can still work, but each email needs its own goal, and contacts should leave the flow once they complete the target action. Success should be measured on clicks, applications and job posts rather than opens, because Apple Mail Privacy Protection now inflates open counts.

> **Source caveat.** In the research session behind this report, direct page fetches were blocked for most primary sites, including litmus.com, nngroup.com, caniemail.com, stylecampaign.com, emailmarkup.org, support.google.com, Microsoft's Tech Community and RFC/RePEc pages. The findings therefore come from **web-search summaries of those pages and from secondary sites that quote them**, not from full reads of the originals. Exact percentages should be read as "reported by", and the report says where a figure appears only on an aggregator or where sources conflict. Agency and SEO-content figures that could not be traced to a primary study were left out. The brand-colour contrast ratios were **calculated in-session with the WCAG relative-luminance formula** and can be re-checked in any contrast checker.

A 600px single column with 16px text fails most gracefully

Litmus's market-share data, built from more than a billion tracked opens, puts Apple Mail and Gmail together at "nearly 90%" of opens (Litmus). The split between them moves from month to month. One secondary summary gives Apple 45.51% and Gmail 23.54% for February 2026 (Demandsage summary of Litmus); another gives Apple 62.26% and Gmail 27.03% for July 2026. Apple's share is inflated because MPP-enabled opens cannot reliably be attributed to a client (Litmus blog). Several aggregators attribute a device split of **about 42% mobile, 41% webmail and 16% desktop** to Litmus (Mailmodo), but no Litmus primary page confirming it could be read. Because webmail, which is mostly Gmail, is about as large as mobile, the layout cannot depend on media queries or web fonts. The "hybrid" or "spongy" pattern is fluid by default, uses `max-width` to cap the width at 600px, and adapts without media queries, so it degrades most safely (Litmus: responsive vs hybrid). Vendors

consistently recommend a single column for mobile because multi-column modules stack unpredictably (Zoho ZeptoMail). No controlled test of 600px against other widths was found; the convention rests on practitioner consensus. GoFindBuild's job seekers are a phone-first audience, so their real mobile share is probably well above the blended 42%. HubSpot's device report will confirm the actual figure.

Typography should assume the brand font will not render. Per caniemail, as reported in search summaries, only about **22% of tested clients fully support** `@font-face`, or about 29% including partial support (caniemail). Apple Mail renders web fonts reliably, Gmail web strips them, and classic Outlook for Windows ignores them and can fall back to Times New Roman unless a fallback is declared (Scalero; Email on Acid). In practice, many Gmail and Outlook readers will see Arial or Helvetica instead of Inter, so line lengths, heading wraps and button widths should be checked in Arial. HubSpot's drag-and-drop editor now supports custom brand-kit fonts in a beta (KB updated April 2026), but each custom font requires a chosen fallback, and recipients whose clients do not support custom fonts see that fallback (HubSpot KB). For size, Style Campaign's iOS testing found that older iOS versions auto-enlarged small text, while newer devices render it at the specified size. It notes that 16px is the default in many browsers and 17px is the body size on newer iPhones (Style Campaign). Adobe recommends at least 16px for body text (Adobe Experience League), and Ohio State's email guide asks for 14px on desktop and 16px on mobile (OSU). No email-specific research on line height or line length was found. A line height of about 1.5 and lines of roughly 50–75 characters are general typographic conventions, not tested email findings.

Several client rendering limits should be treated as fixed constraints when designing. **Gmail clips messages whose HTML exceeds about 102KB.** Only the code counts, not image file sizes, and clipping hides the footer (including the unsubscribe link and postal address) and can cut off the open-tracking pixel (SendGrid; Email on Acid). Classic Outlook for Windows renders with the Word engine, so it ignores `border-radius` (buttons get square corners) and CSS background images (Kontent.ai; Elastic Email). It also shows only the first frame of an animated GIF (Microsoft Support), and neither classic Outlook nor, reliably, Gmail displays SVG (OnVoard). Litmus's iOS 10 guidance adds the `x-apple-disable-message-reformatting` and viewport meta tags to stop iOS Mail from rescaling layouts (Litmus); no current source confirms whether iOS 17 or 18 still needs them. The research did not establish whether HubSpot's drag-and-drop wrapper includes these tags or how much it adds to the 102KB budget. A test send can answer both questions.

Readers give an email 51 seconds, so lead with one live-text action

NN/g's eye-tracking found an average of **51 seconds** spent on a newsletter after opening it, with only 19% fully read and scanning as the dominant behaviour (NN/g; Campaign Monitor quoting NN/g). NN/g also judged scannability about **50% more important for newsletters than for websites** (Smart Insights summary). This research dates from the mid-2000s and has not been replicated on modern mobile email, but its implication is consistent with everything else here. The first phone screen should show the headline, the benefit and the button, with supporting detail below in inverted-pyramid order. The commonly quoted "first 500–600px" fold height could not be traced to a source and is a working assumption.

For CTAs, the evidence favours HTML live-text ("bulletproof") buttons. Campaign Monitor measured **28% more click-throughs from a button than from a text link** (Campaign Monitor). Litmus notes that image buttons disappear when images are off and cannot be read by screen readers (Litmus). Tap

targets should be at least **44×44**: Apple's Human Interface Guidelines specify 44pt and WCAG 2.5.5 (AAA) specifies 44 CSS px, while WCAG 2.5.8 (AA) sets a 24px minimum (GOV.UK WCAG primer; Smashing Magazine). Full-width mobile buttons give the largest target. For a reader on a job site wearing gloves, that matters more than usual, though this audience benefit is inferred rather than tested. The evidence on how many CTAs to use is mixed. A widely reported Whirlpool case found a 42% click lift from cutting four CTAs to one, but only secondary reports were available (BNP Media). In a Klaviyo test, a two-offer email narrowly beat a single offer for new customers, while a single CTA won a later reminder test (Klaviyo case study). The defensible rule is **one primary action, optionally repeated at the bottom, with any secondary links styled as plain text**. The often-quoted "371% more clicks from a single CTA" could not be traced to a study and should not be cited.

Images should support the message, not carry it. Gmail and Outlook.com no longer block images by default, but some Outlook desktop configurations still do, and screen readers can read only alt text (Email on Acid). The 60/40 image-to-text rule is largely a myth. Email on Acid tested against 23 spam filters and found that **emails with 500 or more characters of live text were unaffected by their image ratio** (Email on Acid; Movable Ink). Image-only emails remain risky, however, and SpamAssassin still penalises a low text-to-image area (Suped). A further point follows from the width arithmetic rather than from a study: a 600px design on a 375px phone screen is scaled to about 62%, so text inside screenshots of the GoFindBuild app becomes unreadable. Screenshots should be cropped tightly to a single UI element, with the instruction written in live text.

The case for designed emails is weaker than designers might expect. In HubSpot's internal tests, the simpler email won every A/B test. An image-rich HTML template had a **21% lower click-through rate**, and a plain-text version drew **42% more clicks** than a version with a GIF once its higher open rate was counted (HubSpot). Parcel's five-month welcome-flow test also found that the text-based version converted better, although the authors called the comparison "not apples to apples" and a reported click-rate figure appears to contradict the result (Parcel). All of this is vendor-run, predates MPP, and has not been replicated with a trades audience. The defensible position is a **lightly branded email that reads like a letter**: a logo, a short headline, short paragraphs and one button. The plain founder-style version is the challenger to test against it.

Brand orange fails AA and the navy logo vanishes in dark mode

Accessibility failures in marketing email are close to universal. The Email Markup Consortium's 2026 report found **serious or critical issues in 99.88% of 376,348 emails**, with only 8 emails from 3 brands passing every check (beSpacific summary). The most common failures are mechanical: a missing `dir` attribute (97.41%), a missing body-level `lang` (95.66%) and layout tables not marked `role="presentation"` (84%), as reported by a secondary source (unspam.email). The relevant WCAG thresholds are **4.5:1 contrast for normal text and 3:1 for large text** (at least 24px regular or 18.66px bold), 3:1 for UI component boundaries, no meaning conveyed by colour alone (so underline inline links), and descriptive link text (W3C SC 1.4.3; W3C SC 1.4.1; W3C SC 2.4.4). The research did not establish whether HubSpot's drag-and-drop output includes `lang`, `dir` and `role="presentation"`. Viewing the source of a test send will show this.

Measured against those thresholds, GoFindBuild's palette has one clear failure and one dark-mode problem. The ratios below were calculated in-session; the darker orange #B85309 is a suggested alternative, not a brand-approved colour.

Foreground on background	Ratio	Normal text (4.5:1)	Large text / UI (3:1)
Navy #16243D on white	15.51:1	Pass	Pass
White on orange #F16C0E (typical button)	**3.05:1**	**Fail**	Pass, barely
Orange #F16C0E text or links on white	3.05:1	**Fail**	Pass
Navy #16243D on orange #F16C0E	**5.09:1**	Pass	Pass
Orange on navy	5.09:1	Pass	Pass
Orange on dark-mode grey #121212	6.15:1	Pass	Pass
Navy on dark-mode grey #121212	**1.21:1**	**Fail**	**Fail**
Navy on black	1.35:1	Fail	Fail
White on darker orange #B85309 (alternative)	4.91:1	Pass	Pass

The practical consequence is that **an orange button with a white 16px label fails AA**. There are three ways to fix it. A navy label on orange keeps both brand colours and passes cleanly. A white label at 18.66px bold or larger passes only the large-text threshold, by a fragile 0.05. A darker orange such as #B85309 passes with white text but changes the brand colour. Orange should never be used for body text or inline links on white.

Dark mode adds a second layer of risk because clients handle it in three different ways: no change, partial invert (only light backgrounds are darkened) and full invert. Litmus's and Email on Acid's reference charts disagree on Apple Mail and Gmail Android, so real-client tests are the only reliable check (Litmus dark mode guide; Parcel). Apple Mail honours `@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark)`. Outlook exposes `[data-ogsc]` and `[data-ogsb]` attribute hooks instead. **Gmail offers no dark-mode hook at all** (freeCodeCamp). The light design therefore has to degrade acceptably under inversion without help from CSS. A navy logo on a transparent PNG is the clearest casualty: wherever a client darkens the background but leaves images alone, the logo sits at 1.21–1.35:1 and effectively disappears. The fixes that need no code, and therefore suit HubSpot drag-and-drop, are to bake a thin white outline around the logo into the PNG or to place it on a solid white or light rounded panel within the image. A `prefers-color-scheme` logo swap would help Apple Mail users but probably requires a coded template. HubSpot provides a dark-mode preview, but its own documentation describes the preview as an approximation (HubSpot KB). Orange survives dark backgrounds well (6.15:1), though a full invert can shift its hue, so check it in Gmail iOS and classic Outlook. No reliable current figure exists for the share of opens in dark mode. Published estimates range from about 11.5% to 34% and are dated vendor figures (Mailmodo; Publicare).

Subject, preview and sender work as one 80-character unit

Mobile clients truncate subject lines by pixel width. Third-party measurements put the cut at about **33–41 characters in the Gmail app and 40–48 in Apple Mail on iPhone**, and preview text shows

roughly another 40–50 characters (EmailToolTester; Brevo). The value proposition therefore belongs in the first ~35 characters of the subject, with the preview text completing it rather than repeating it. If the preview field is left empty, the client shows the first visible body text, which is often "View in browser" (Brevo).

Personalization has the strongest academic evidence of any element here, and that evidence is genuinely mixed. Sahni, Wheeler and Chintagunta's field experiments in *Marketing Science* (2018) found that adding the recipient's name to the subject line **raised the probability of opening by 20% and cut unsubscribes by 17%** (INFORMS). A 2023 replication in *Marketing Letters* found **no first-name effect** on opens or clicks; only surname personalization helped (RePEc/IDEAS). First names in subject lines are therefore something to A/B test, not a guaranteed win. Relevance to the reader's trade, city or job matches is the more defensible lever for a job marketplace, though that point is an inference. Emoji evidence is weak and contradictory, and NN/g found emoji did not make people more likely to open (EmailToolTester). In HubSpot, a token with no default renders blank, which produces "Hi ," for contacts missing a first name. Defaults can be set globally or per email (HubSpot KB). Write the copy so the fallback reads naturally, for example `Hi {{firstname | default "there"}},` renders as "Hi there,", and avoid placing a token mid-sentence between commas.

Sender-name tests all point the same direction but vary widely in size. A personal sender beat a company name by 0.53 points of open rate in HubSpot's test (Campaign Monitor) and by 38% relative in a NextAfter experiment (NextAfter). No peer-reviewed study was found. "Brian from GoFindBuild", with a monitored reply-to address, captures the personal effect while keeping the brand visible. All of these tests measured opens, and Litmus reports that MPP affects roughly **55–60% of opens** by pre-fetching tracking pixels (Litmus; Postmark). Subject-line and sender A/B tests should therefore be judged on clicks or conversions.

Long welcome flows need exits, compliance and click-based KPIs

Welcome and automated emails consistently outperform regular campaigns, mainly on clicks and conversions rather than opens. In Omnisend's comparison, open rates for automations and campaigns were nearly identical (about 30.2% and 30.4%), but **click rates were 4.66% versus 0.74%** (Omnisend benchmarks). Its 2023 data showed 1.9% conversion for automated emails against 0.04% for campaigns (Omnisend 2024 report). Klaviyo reports that welcome emails average a 51% open rate (Klaviyo). GetResponse's far higher figures (83.63% opens) probably reflect differences in how opens are counted (GetResponse). All of these are ecommerce benchmarks. No benchmark for job boards, two-sided marketplaces or construction audiences was found, so "application submitted" and "job posted" will need their own internal baselines.

On length and cadence, Klaviyo recommends **three emails over about a week**: one immediately, a second three days later and a third four days after that, with at least a day between emails. It describes the count as a recommendation rather than a rule (Klaviyo Help). No controlled study isolating series length was found. GoFindBuild's 7-email and 6-email flows are therefore longer than the default but not wrong. Each email after the first three needs its own goal, and HubSpot goal criteria should remove contacts once they apply or post a job. Without that exit, a long drift of emails raises spam-complaint risk.

That risk is now a hard constraint. Google requires bulk senders to keep spam rates below 0.10% and never reach 0.30%, and to support one-click unsubscribe through `List-Unsubscribe` and `List-`

`Unsubscribe-Post` headers in addition to a visible unsubscribe link in the body (Google sender guidelines; Red Sift). Yahoo also requires the header, citing RFC 8058, and states that a body link alone is not enough (Yahoo Sender Hub). Microsoft began enforcing SPF, DKIM and DMARC for senders of more than 5,000 messages a day to Outlook.com consumer domains on **May 5, 2025**. Summaries disagree on whether non-compliant mail goes to Junk or is rejected (Mailgun). CAN-SPAM requires a physical postal address and opt-out processing within 10 business days (FTC). These requirements connect back to design: an email clipped at 102KB hides exactly the footer that carries the unsubscribe link and postal address.

GoFindBuild HubSpot welcome-email redesign spec

The spec below turns the findings into settings for both flows. Items marked *verify* depend on HubSpot behaviour or account settings that the research could not confirm.

Area	Spec for both flows
Layout	One column per section; content max-width 600px (HubSpot default); no 2- or 3-column modules except a footer; mobile padding 16–20px per side
First screen (phone)	Logo, a headline of 10 words or fewer, 1–2 sentences of benefit, primary button, all visible without scrolling
Font	Inter through the HubSpot brand-kit custom-font beta (*verify enrolment*), with Arial or Helvetica as the fallback; check line wraps and button widths in Arial
Type scale	Body 16px, line height about 1.5; h1 24–28px; h2 20px; nothing below 14px, including the footer; use real heading styles, not bolded paragraphs
Text colour	Body and headings navy #16243D on white (15.51:1); inline links navy and underlined, never orange
Primary button	Native HubSpot Button module (live text); orange #F16C0E fill with a **navy label** (5.09:1), or #B85309 with a white label (4.91:1) if white text is required; at least 44px tall (16px bold label plus about 14px vertical padding); full width on mobile; verb-first label naming the outcome (“Finish my profile”, “Post my first job”); expect square corners in classic Outlook
CTA count	One primary action, optionally repeated once at the end; anything secondary is a text link
Images	Hero optional; no text inside images; every meaningful image gets alt text, decorative images get `alt=""`; app screenshots cropped to one UI element; export at 2x, displayed at 600px or less; any GIF works as a still on its first frame; no SVG
Logo / dark mode	Re-export the navy logo PNG with a thin white outline or on a white rounded panel; check in HubSpot’s dark-mode preview, then in Gmail iOS, Apple Mail (dark) and classic Outlook

Area	Spec for both flows
Live text	At least about 500 characters of live text per email; headline, value proposition and CTA never image-only
HTML weight	Well under 102KB; check the size of a test send's source; vary subject lines between test sends so Gmail does not thread and clip them
Accessibility	Check the sent source for `lang="en"`, `dir="ltr"` and `role="presentation"` on layout tables (*verify HubSpot output*); descriptive link text; no "click here"
Subject / preview	Key words in the first ~35 characters; preview text always filled and adding new information (40–50 characters); no reliance on emoji
Personalization	Global and per-email token defaults set (for example "there"); copy reads correctly with the fallback; first-name-in-subject only as an A/B test; prefer trade, city or job-match relevance
Sender	"Brian from GoFindBuild" (or the actual founder or recruiter name) with a monitored reply-to address; test against the company name on clicks
Compliance	SPF, DKIM and DMARC for the sending domain connected in HubSpot; one-click unsubscribe headers (*verify HubSpot handles them*); visible unsubscribe link and postal address in every footer
Flow logic	Email 1 sent immediately on signup; at least one day between emails; HubSpot goal criteria or branches remove contacts once they apply or post a job; spam complaints kept below 0.1%
Measurement	Judge on click rate, click-to-open, applications and job posts; treat opens as directional only (MPP)

The two flows should differ in format, not in standards. **Job seekers** are on phones, often outdoors and sometimes wearing gloves. Their emails should be the leanest version of the spec: a full-width button, very short paragraphs, and one action per email. A reasonable proposed arc is to open with a plain "Brian" welcome asking them to finish their profile, follow with emails that each move one step (add trade and skills, turn on job alerts, apply to a first matched job, add certifications or references), and close with a short reply-to check-in. Contacts should leave the flow as soon as they apply. **Employers** (contractors) read more on desktop and in Outlook, so classic-Outlook rendering, square button corners and the Arial fallback matter more for this flow. A proposed arc runs from a welcome and "post your first job", through tips on writing a strong post, reviewing applicants and using search or filters, to a check-in, with an exit once a job is posted. Both arcs are proposals built from the one-goal-per-email logic, not tested sequences. One A/B test per flow is enough to start: a plain founder-style email 1 against the branded template, judged on clicks.

Conclusion

The evidence matters most here for what it shows to be weak. Practices widely treated as rules, including the 60/40 image ratio, the “371%” single-CTA lift, a 13px iOS minimum and first-name subject lines, turn out to be myths, untraceable, or contradicted by replication. The constraints that do hold up are client rendering behaviour, WCAG contrast arithmetic and mailbox-provider sender rules, and these are things a team can test against directly rather than infer. The GoFindBuild redesign therefore has a clear priority order. First, fix what is measurably broken: the white-on-orange button labels, the navy logo in dark mode, empty token fallbacks, and the accessibility attributes in HubSpot’s output. Second, simplify each email to one live-text action. Third, use HubSpot A/B tests to settle the open questions (plain versus designed, sender name, flow length) on clicks and job actions, since no published benchmark covers a trades marketplace.

Before treating any figure here as definitive, re-verify the per-client support tables on caniemail.com, Litmus’s current dark-mode chart and Google’s sender-guideline page from a session that can reach those sites. This research had to rely on search summaries of them, and their figures change from month to month.